

Apple's Quarter

Apple sells 14.1mn iPhones, scores another record-breaking quarter

Sony's Treat!

Sony's Xperia X10 gets an Eclair Treat with HD video playback. Now it boasts 720p video recording

Taking the first step towards protecting your investment

This Diwali, make sure you're buying smart, and buying safe; it is your hard-earned money we're talking about here after all, isn't it?

The technology industry has scaled new heights over the past few years. However, so have your problems as a consumer. Products just aren't built the way they used to be, and if you're not careful, you might end up with a dud, and one you paid a pretty penny for too. How do you avoid getting ripped-off, when you go out and buy this festival season? It's hard isn't it, with thousands of offers being thrown in your face, and cut-throat price wars vying for your attention.

All you really have on your side is knowledge. If you prepare yourself you can navigate through the treacherous waters that our shopping malls have become – relatively unscathed. It is, after all, a lot better to be careful before you buy than to run about from pillar to post trying to get a faulty product repaired, or approaching a consumer court to try and get some justice, if you were cheated.

The operative word here is "consumer". This is because as a consumer, you graduate from being a mere buyer, to someone, anyone, who consumes the goods or services that you (or someone else) paid for. This could be eatables bought from a shop, a service you paid for, or basically anything in which a monetary transaction was involved.

The Consumer Protection Act of 1986 confirms this, by dealing with the word "consumer" in two ways. The first is with respect to goods, and the second pertains to services. This is important to know, because the term consumer covers a lot more; it includes not just the person who actually paid for a

product or service, but also the person who consumed it. For example, if your parents bought you a gadget – although the bill may be in your father's name, if something went wrong, both you and your father would have equal rights to demand compensation as per the warranty terms and conditions, and also be equally eligible to initiate action against a service provider or seller, who did not fulfill the promise of warranty.

Before any purchase, you should use any means to find out more about the actual product/service and the brand name you're paying for. You can do this by consulting with other buyers, or just looking up reviews online. There are dedicated web sites that provide immense information and comparisons of products, without the bias of a seller

be there today. Try getting a replacement if something goes wrong, and you could even get beaten up in extreme cases. And for what? A few Rupees less? Is it really worth the hassle? Also, you could be buying pirated products, or cheap knock-offs, and paying almost full price!

Brands and warranties

A lot of new companies enter the market well-prepared, and are often looking to gain as much market share by giving you irresistible offers. Before you buy anything from a new brand, try and find out more about them. For example, don't be afraid to ask the seller how many of the brand's service centres are in your city, and how many are near your home or office. Also make it a point to read their warranty terms. Sometimes you might find that new brands offer better warranty terms, such as an onsite warranty, as opposed to carry-in by other brands. Of course the reverse might also hold true, as not all new brands can afford this. In certain

categories, such as TVs or refrigerators, where an onsite warranty is the norm, it's all the more important to check the terms for a new brand, and not just assume that everything's as expected.

We can help!
If you're facing a problem with your purchase, write to us at help@consumermate.com

who may just be trying to offload the stock that hasn't been selling.

Where you buy

Next on your list of things to be careful about is where you're buying your product from. It's obviously better to buy from more reputed outlets, and try as far as possible to avoid roadside vendors for important technology purchases. You never know what you're getting from these roadside shops, and many of them are fly-by-night operators. Just because you saw them there yesterday, doesn't guarantee that they'll

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